10 Feeding Surprises

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Credits

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20th ANNIVERSARY EDITION

VAMPIRE

THE MASQUERADE

Introduction

"Dis-moi ce que tu manges, je te dirai ce que tu es. (Tell me what you eat and I will tell you what you are)."

– Jean Anthelme Brillat-Savarin; *Physiologie du Gout, ou Meditations de Gastronomie Transcendante*

Greetings, dear reader.

Feeding, the act of drinking blood, is something very, very central to vampires. In fact, one could argue that what makes a vampire a vampire, is the act of drinking blood.

In some games, the acts of hunting and feeding are glossed over, while in others, they are a central part of the story. Presented here are 10 feeding surprises that can be inserted into any game, whether the hunt is an integral and dramatic part of the story or whether it is usually handled quicker and more abstractly.

With these little surprises, I have kept away from what one might call the "usual suspects" – not Lupines, no surprise True Faith, no wizards or fae or other supernatural creatures. Instead, I have gone for events that can heighten drama, lead to further stories or even provide a moment or dark humor to the game at hand.

Bon Appetit!

Chapter One: 10 Feeding Surprises

"I am not left-handed either!"

— The Man in Black; *The Princess Bride*

1: Holy crap, it's you!

"Wait a minute, you know this guy."

The target of the feeding is some minor or local celebrity that the vampire in question actually knows, and possibly even is a fan of. It could be a member of some obscure goth band, a local news reporter, a niche author, a YouTube or Twitch personality – the possibilities are endless. The two most important things are:

1: The celebrity is very minor, someone who cannot reach a national audience and whose possible disappearance would not become an overnight sensation.

2: The character actually knows who the person is. It certainly carries more emotional weight if the character is actually a fan, though imagine the possibilities if a strongly political character finds herself feeding on a local talk radio personality with the exact opposite opinions.

This encounter can lead in a number of directions. Maybe the character foregoes feeding, afraid of the potential threat to the masquerade from even a minor celebrity. Maybe they take some time to fanboy, or go in the opposite direction and savagely critique their victim's work. They may try to turn the chance encounter into a new contact or even take their victim as a new ghoul.

This surprise obviously requires a bit of prep work, especially if you want the target to be someone the character is a fan of. Or you may simply state; "It turns out your victim is the singer of that obscure band you like/the host of that small YouTube show you follow/one of the local news anchors you often watch" and let the player take it from there.

2: Do you know who my father is?

"Your dad's a mafia don? Ooops."

Something the character does before, during, or after the feeding causes the target to call upon her parentage – or possibly the character steals the victim's wallet after leaving her dead or unconscious and recognizes the name. The drama here comes from the possibility that the powerful and/or influential parent will learn that their child has been violated. Of course, it need not necessarily be someone's child – it could be a brother, sister, or spouse of someone with significant wealth, power and/or influence.

There are several possibilities when it comes to a powerful parent (or parents). It could be a gang boss or a high-ranking member of organized crime, who might want to put a hurting on anyone who causes trouble for their child. It could be a local politician, such as a city councilmember, a state senator, or even the mayor. It could be a powerful private person, like a high-ranking lawyer, a wealthy business tycoon, or a media personality with plenty of fans.

If the powerful family tie is discovered before the feeding, the character may break it off and be forced to seek vitae elsewhere. If it happens afterwards, the character is now faced with the dilemma of how to prevent their victim from relating what has happened. Crafty characters may turn this to their advantage, using it as a way to get to the power and influence represented by their target's relations.

3: I think I love you.

"Will you *stop* following me around!"

This surprise works best if the character uses some form of seduction method as their way of hunting, but considering the pleasure of the Kiss, it may happen to anyone who leaves their victim alive. The target gains an unhealthy fixation on the character and becomes a stalker.

At the very least, this is a massive threat to the Masquerade, especially if the character does not realize that she is being stalked. The stalker may see, and even record, things of a supernatural nature. However, even without the Masquerade, a stalker is a big problem – they are obsessive and mentally unhinged, able and willing to take very drastic actions with regards to the object of their infatuation. A stalker will be violently jealous of anyone that the character shows any affection towards, which might cause trouble for the character's contacts, allies, or ghouls. Depending on how the character hunts, the stalker could very easily make hunting more difficult as he or she follows the character around.

Should the character see their stalker as a resource, they are in for a rude awakening – turning their former victim into a ghoul will result in a massive increase in the obsessive tendencies, while trying to get their stalker to act on their behalf will only work if they can provide them with a lot of affection and single-minded attention.

4: You haven't changed a bit.

"Hey, it's me, Jerry. Jerry from high school, remember?"

This surprise works best if the character has stayed local, though it can be used in other situations. It turns out that the character's intended victim is someone who knew them when they were alive. Someone who recognizes them.

Depending on the time frame, the reaction can range from "You look the same" to "What's you secret? No gluten?" to "You haven't changed a bit in 30 years!" and has the potential to threaten the Masquerade. However, such a threat is not the only problem – if the character has surviving family or friends that they have cut ties with, especially by faking their own death, meeting someone who knows them can have very dangerous repercussions.

In addition to the trouble of having to explain themselves, such a meeting can also stir up old emotions. Imagine a kid who was bullied throughout their high school years meeting up with one of the bullies after having been Embraced – Self-Control rolls would definitely be in order. Or maybe the intended victim is an old crush who ignored the character, an old one-night stand that ended awkwardly, or a former best friend who moved away.

5: You're on what?

"The walls seem to be bleeding. That's not good."

This kind of surprise is very appropriate for someone who feeds in a club, though it could happen to almost anyone. The character's victim is on drugs and now, those drugs are affecting the character too.

Before using this surprise, it's a good idea to do a bit of research on the effect of various recreational drugs (though please, no practical tests). Some give boundless energy, some make you lethargic, some cause hallucinations, while new, cutting-edge designer drugs might have all sorts of peculiar effects. Self-Control or Courage rolls might be needed.

The effect stays with the character for as long as the drugged blood stays in the vampire's system, or until the next night. In addition to the trouble the character might cause while under the influence of the drug, up to and including breaching the Masquerade, there is also the possibility of addiction. After all, there is a reason why people keep taking drugs.

6: Typhoid Mary.

"My herd seems to be dying."

A relative of the surprise mentioned above, except the victim of the character's feeding suffers from some blood-borne disease, rather than being under the influence of drugs. This disease now lurks in the character's blood until the tainted vitae is used up. The character has a chance of infecting anyone they bite and will certainly transfer the disease if they feed their blood to someone else.

This surprise is especially devastating for characters that have a herd or who maintain a large amount of ghouls, as the disease can run rampant through the character's servants or vessels.

Using this surprise might require a bit of research on the effects of various diseases, as well as what diseases are blood-borne. The old standby is AIDS, which has the added bonus of being incurable. However, know your group – if any of your players have had a certain disease or someone close to them have, you probably don't want to bring it up in the game.

7: That's poaching.

"I swear, I didn't know he was yours"

The character inadvertently feeds on a mortal or ghoul belonging to another vampire. This can either be discovered during the feeding, when the character tastes the presence of vampire blood or the mortal seems to have too good of an idea of what is going on, or afterwards, as the character's victim relates their experience to their master. It may also happen before the feeding, though in this case, there is less drama.

How the affronted party reacts depends on who the Kindred affected is. Someone who is already antagonistic towards the character, or who puts a lot of stock in domain and the sanctity of resource, may raise it as a point to the city's Elders or even the prince. They will certainly use it against the character. A neutral Kindred might be turned into an enemy, while an ally could simply say "You owe me one" and let it slide.

One interesting variation, if the various player characters don't know each other's herd or ghouls very well, is to arrange it so that one character feeds on a mortal that is part of another character's domain and simply let the players play out the confrontation.

8: Hey, I'm a vampire too.

"Can I drink from you afterwards?"

This surprise requires the right setting, like an underground club or possibly some kind of convention. The character's intended victim turns out to be a mortal who is into some kind of vampire subculture – it may be just a sexual thing, or role-playing, or it may be an individual who has embraced (pardon the pun) an "unlifestyle". Whatever the case, the target mistakes the character for "one of his own" and may be in for the time or their life or a rude awakening.

If you want to up the ante, perhaps the character's target is an actual vampire, like them – they may be new to the city, or maybe the character is the newcomer, or the intended victim is a neonate recently release (or, even more interestingly, not released yet). If the city is large enough and the Kindred population big enough, it might even be that the two vampires just haven't met yet.

9: I know what you did.

"Hey! You! Let him go!"

This surprise works best if the character is doing a violent feeding, like an ambush or a snatch-and-grab. Unbeknownst to them, their victim is being watched somehow. Maybe they have chosen an undercover cop or a criminal who's under police surveillance. Maybe their target is being followed by a detective because their spouse suspects them of cheating (this would be a great surprise for someone seducing their target). Or maybe their victim has one or more bodyguards who keep a respectful distance. Hell, it could be as simple as the target having one more friend who's just stepped off for a bathroom break or a smoke or something similar.

Whatever the case, the character is now faced with one or more witnesses, possibly with recorded evidence. At the very least, it looks like they have mugged someone. In the most extreme case, there is now a Masquerade-threatening cell phone video out there.

10: I... don't feel so... good.

"Anyone know how to get rid of a corpse?"

This surprise requires the character to not want to kill their victim. However, they have chosen someone with a weak constitution, a heart defect, or some other condition that means that the stress of the feeding (or possibly just the fear of realizing what's about to happen) kills them.

In addition to the effect this might have on the character's humanity, there is also the question of what to do with the body. Most characters are unlikely to know how to properly dispose of a corpse and depending on where the death happened, they might not have long to act. In addition, if people saw them with the victim before he died and the target then disappears, the character could easily be a person of interest in a police investigation, something that can easily threaten the Masquerade.